EU targets signing of Indonesia trade deal on Nov 21

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By Koen Verhelst, Camille Gijs · Nov 3, 2026, 3:48 PM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — The EU and Indonesia tentatively plan to sign their trade deal on Nov. 21, two diplomats and a business representative told POLITICO, subject to approval by EU ministers.

Jakarta hopes hopes that the deal can enter into force before the end of the year, as it is due to lose other EU trade benefits on Jan. 1, 2027. Signing the deal on Nov. 21 would make that theoretically possible.

One EU official indicated that the date “is the plan” for now. The official, like others contacted for this article, was granted anonymity to discuss the closed-door deliberations.

European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen reached a broad political agreement on trade with President Prabowo Subianto in July 2025 — part of the EU’s push to diversify its trade relationships into the Asia-Pacific in response to U.S. President Donald Trump’s trade protectionism.

France has been blocking progress on the deal after the European Commission sought to expedite the process by only preparing an English translation to be signed by both sides. Paris insists on a French translation that has also been authenticated by Jakarta.

EU ambassadors are due to discuss the deal on Wednesday, but they will not be clearing the way for it to be approved as early as Nov. 9 at a meeting of economy and finance ministers.

“The big question is what the French will do,” an EU diplomat told POLITICO Tuesday, referring to the ambassador’s meeting. Wednesday’s meeting “is a state of play, not meant to approve the Council decisions,” the diplomat clarified.

It is unclear why the signing ceremony would take place on a Saturday, which would be unusual.

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